country's first Prime Minister and External Affairs Minister, Nehru played a significant role in shaping the eventual outcomes. But it is important to note that there was not always consensus among leaders within his Indian National Congress (such as Patel, Prasad, or Rajaji), let alone among its political opponents such as Ambedkar and Mookerjee, about the direction that a newly independent India should take.

The balance of consensus initially rested on a three-fold approach. First, and least controversially, the country would be governed as a Westminster-style democratic republic. This was an ambitious vision, given that the majority of voting-age Indians were then illiterate, and few countries had offered full women's suffrage at the outset. But a parliamentary democracy appeared to be the only practical way to manage a country of India's diversity. India also had an experience and tradition of democracy within the framework of the Indian National Congress (which would regularly elect presidents) and of governance in British-administered territory due to the Government of India Acts of 1861, 1909, and 1919. The last Indian provincial elections held before Independence were in 1946. After 1947, a democratic Constitution was drafted, deliberated, and amended by India's Constituent Assembly, as part of a process led by Ambedkar. The Constitution came into force in 1950. [9]

The second element of India's policy orientation after Independence involved a significant degree of state direction over the economy and industry. It was informed heavily by the Fabian Socialist leanings of Nehru and other Congress leaders—supportive of gradualist social democratic reforms—and were consistent with many of the economic orthodoxies of that time, including in Britain. State-led economic planning gained further credence due to the successes at that point of Soviet industrialization and of the New Deal in the United States, which saw government spending and employment to stimulate recovery following the Great Depression. To various degrees, the idea of state planning was contested by other leaders (Rajaji eventually founded the Swatantra Party which advocated an alternate approach). The likes of Matthai, India's second finance minister, and Patel, the first deputy prime minister and home minister, protested the